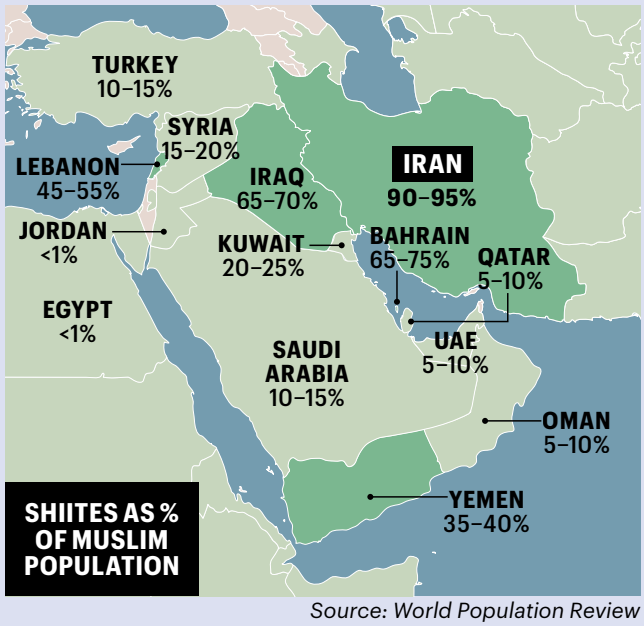
SHIA-SUNNI DIVIDE

ANCIENT SCHISM

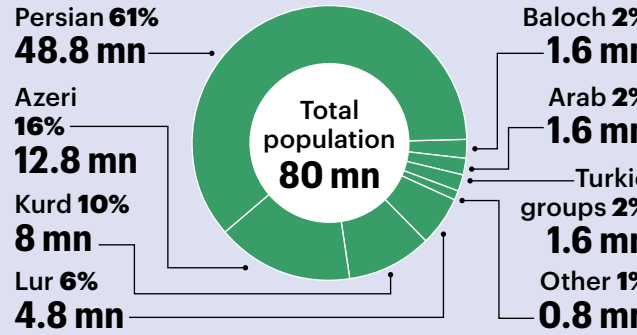
Shia-majority Iran has struck its largely Sunni-majority neighbours in a fast-escalating conflict



Source: World Population Review

IRAN'S ETHNIC GROUPS

MOSAIC OF IDENTITIES



Note: The last census on ethnicity in Iran was done in 1976
Source: Minority Rights Group

FORMER ENVOY K.C. SINGH THINKS NETANYAHU AND TRUMP ARE USING THIS WAR AS DIVERSION. BIBI FACES ELECTIONS LATER THIS YEAR, TRUMP CONGRESSIONAL POLLS IN THE US

Trump deploying US troops on the ground in Iran. She points out that Iran is something of a black box for Washington, as the US has not had diplomatic representation in the country for nearly 50 years. If the US deployed 150,000 troops in Iraq, she notes, it would require four times the number for Iran's far larger size. "If the past is prologue, and if we look at our experience in Iraq and Libya," she says, "the outlook in Iran would be grim. It is ten times more complex than Iraq. There just are no good options or outcomes."

That's because past US invasions failed to grasp the degree to which these dictatorial, repressive regimes penetrate almost every institution of state and society. When you abruptly uproot a regime, its coterie and its tentacles, it normally leads to chaos. An invading force seldom has the capacity to run institutions or deliver basic services to the masses. Iran, for instance, has two million people in its security forces. Would the US bomb all of them? In Iraq, the US disbanded Saddam Hussein's armed forces, only to have many of them later join radical groups, including the ISIS.

In analysing the opening gambits, many experts see Trump's decision to unleash a war of this magnitude when he had viable diplomatic options as a folly. K.C. Singh, a former Indian ambassador to Iran, says, "Each one is making gross miscalculations because they are using this war to divert troubling domestic issues. Netanyahu because he faces elections later this year, and Trump because Congressional elections will determine whether he retains his political dominance."

THE NEW MIDDLE EAST

Wars rarely end simply because weapons run out. They end when one side concludes that the costs of continuing exceed the costs of stopping. Akbaruddin says, "America may lose interest if there is no easy regime change. Having bombed Iran's nuclear plants and missiles out of shape, Trump may not care anymore. He may say, 'I have done my best, now you guys do what you want'." Nor is the war likely to assume the religious or historical dimension of a Shia-Sunni conflict. The Gulf states know they will have to pay too heavy a price for a protracted battle that may destroy their decades-old prosperity. They would prefer to de-escalate.

Whatever the outcome, the conflict will give rise to a new Middle East. It is unlikely that Gulf states will draw closer to Israel. Expediency led a couple of Gulf countries to sign the Abraham Accords during Trump's first term, largely to reap the economic rewards of peace. But, barring the UAE and Bahrain, many in the region increasingly view Israel as a belligerent actor and a potential security concern. Tensions, for instance, have been rising between Israel and Saudi Arabia over Riyadh's support for Palestine and Israel's continued annexation of parts of the West Bank. This is probably what prompted Saudi Arabia to deepen its strategic security ties with Pakistan, partly as a hedge against the perceived threat of a nuclear-armed Israel.

If Israel emerges more dominant after the war with Iran, regional states may well form a broad coalition that could act as a countervailing force. The Middle East would then see a significant reconfiguration of partnerships and alliances. For now, however, neither side seems close to making such calculations. The war continues to be driven by immediate military objectives rather than long-term geopolitical goals. And that is precisely what makes it so dangerous—and its duration so difficult to predict. ■